26 Pebbles

By Eric Ulloa

Suggested Roles --

ACTOR: *Mike, Actors 2, 3, 4, 5 and 6, Darren, Father, President Obama's Speech, Rabbi, Father Weiss, Bill, Joe*
ACTRESS: *Jenn, Superintendent Message, Carole, Carrie, Georgia, Starr, Sally, Carla, Yolie*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

JENN: **(Pg 13)** Communities like ours don't just form themselves. A true sense of community comes from strangers wanting to come together and know one another for the greater good of their neighborhood. And we need more of that nowadays, right?

MIKE: You know on [December 13, 2012], you didn't know where Newtown was or that we had a flagpole, or a creamery, or a parade. Obscure was nice.

JENN: He's right. Obscurity was nice. **(Pg 14)** They say the world is connected through six degrees, but out here in Newtown, it's about one. And if you were born and raised here, everyone is family. **(PG 20)** There are a lot of people from other areas that moved here. [See] Newtown was written up as one of the top ten places to raise kids.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *On December 14, 2012, Adam Lanza killed his mother, then walked into Sandy Hook Elementary School and killed twenty-six innocent souls before taking his own life.*
ACTRESS: *These twenty-six innocent deaths, like pebbles thrown into a pond, created ripples and vibrations that were felt far beyond the initial rings.*
ACTOR: *This is the story of those vibrations.*
ACTRESS: *Playwright Eric Ulloa conducted interviews with members of the community in Newtown and crafted them into an exploration of gun violence and a small town shaken by a horrific event.*
TOGETHER: *26 Pebbles by Eric Ulloa*

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SUPERINTENDENT MESSAGE: **(Pg 22-23)** All Newtown public schools are in lockdown due to a shooting.

MIKE: I hear sirens from a distance, like rally far out. We were walking back to the office and at the Subway there were four teachers. I intercepted them and I said, "What's going on?" And they were in shock and tears. And they said, "Something very very bad. Gunshots. Many gunshots."

ACTOR 6: All clergy go down to the firehouse immediately. All clergy down to the firehouse immediately!

JENN: I got a call saying, "You can pick up your kids at the school, at the firehouse.

MIKE: It's as if somebody open the floodgates right in that moment, and every personnel, police, you name it, first responders in the world was coming.

JENN: **(Pg 25)** I, I just can't even describe how panicked it started to get for me because [my husband] wasn't answering his phone and the texts were flying. "Do you have him?" Where's our son? What's going on?" An I was just leaving him these messages and starting to get that rising panic inside.

DARREN: They said the shooter inside was dead. They said, they, uh, he was *(Sniffles)* He was found dead in a classroom, found in a classroom. I knew that was the worst case. Shoot . . . shoot . . . shooter killing himself. I – I knew he didn't just walk in and shoot himself in front of the kids. *(Sniffles)* And the numbers, we just watched in horror, as it went from a handful . . .to a dozen . . . twenty. *(Beat)*

CAROLE: **(Pg 29-30)** The safety of this little town has been shattered. I think that's the biggest thing that happened her, the shattering of the illusion of . . . our little world. How did this happen to us? What? What just happened here?

FATHER: Don't get me wrong, I think the story needs to be out there. But I'd never seen anything like it in my life. I mean there were literally hundreds and hundreds [of reporters] there in just the first few hours.

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CAROLE: Horrible. Invasive. There was no escape and there was no time for us to grieve. We would all be watching everybody and when somebody went down . . . I mean at the grocery store people would, would go down to their knees and there was a hive of people l that would be there to just let them cry. You know? And you can't, you can't do that with the media because it's so intrusive. They just want – many they want you sobbing. They want to see you in pain.

DARREN: **(Pg 31)** There's no place within Newtown or Sandy Hook that you could go It took us to get from our house to Sandy Hook normally, maybe five minutes. The first couple of weeks you'd have to allow at least an hour to get into town because of the traffic jams. People, news truck(s) – Because the highway sign says "Newtown," people pull off the highway just to see. Just to see.

JENN: **(Pg 32)** The next week was just funerals and wakes and – it was – it was pretty indescribable. *(Responds to the flashes from numerous cameras)*

MICHAEL: *(Also responding to camera flashes – he yells at the press)* Please! Just, just let us mourn.

PRESIDENT OBAMA'S SPEECH: **(Pg 33)** . . . And that's what should drive us forward in everything we do. God has called them all home. For those of us who remain, let us find the strength to carry on, and make our country worthy of their memory.

JENN: How could any God let something like that happen?

RABBI: **(Pg 36)** This was not an act of God, this was an act of man. You got free will and that means that anything could happen. Adolf Hitler can happen. Senseless deaths and shootouts and hold-up and robberies can happen and do happen every day in this country.

CARRIE: He did this, it wasn't God's doing. He chose to do this. But I guess my questions are, well, if he had a mental illness then it isn't really free will. He can't help it right? Then my daughter asks me, "Is he in hell?" And we tried to explain: "Well, you know, he was probably sick and he didn't know what he was doing." And then she would ask, "Well if he was sick then that means he wasn't an evil person, so would God forgive him? What if he's

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sorry? Does he still have to go to hell?" These are questions that we as adults don't have the answer for. What does a parent do?

(Actor drops character and delivers the following lines straight to the audience simultaneously with Actress Lines)

ACTOR 2: (Pg 37) In the shooter's home, police found the following

ACTOR 3: A seven-foot pole, with a blade on one side and a spear on the other.

ACTOR 4: A metal bayonet

ACTOR 5: Three samurai swords

ACTOR 6: .323 caliber bolt-action rifle

ACTOR 1: .22 caliber Savage Mark II rifle

ACTOR 3: New articles on the 2008 shooting at Northern Illinois University

ACTOR 6: And inside his gun safe was a holiday card from his mother, [with] a check for the purchase of his next firearm.

JENN: (Pg 37) I'm – I'm angry. Obviously there was a lot more to this story in terms of his upbringing . . . Just the lack of care that he probably received as a child. Did nobody say anything?

GEORGIA: (PG 38) Not that I'm blaming any one persons, but the village raises the child. I think one of the biggest problems was his isolation. We're meant to be connected. And when someone's not connected . . . bad things start to happen.

STARR: (Pg 39) [He] had counseling just before the divorce. Three months prior to this incident, he was fine, then he was disturbed that his Dad and brother moved. He had nobody else to talk to. And that just . . . snapped the camel's back.

STARR: *(continues)* When he was on medication and in therapy, he was the one who would take his shirt off his back to help you. He did tutoring for the younger.

FATHER WEISS: I always have twenty-eight candles out. I believe in forgiveness. And that is one of the big issues. Is it twenty-six or twenty-eight?

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CAROLE: (Pg 40) The thing is, and maybe it's not appropriate, but twenty-eight people died that day. It wasn't twenty-six, it was twenty-eight people who lost their lives. Twenty-eights families that mourned.

BILL: There is no difference between a man who's being chased by someone with a machine gun, and a man who THINKS he's being chased by someone with a machine gun." And the sad part is that he was over eighteen years old, and legally there's not a thing we could do. We're no different from Mrs. Lanza.

SALLY: I think that his mother did everything she possibly could. There is a point where you are scared, you're afraid, but it's your son. And you have hope because he's not a monster, he's mentally ill. Some people honestly just don't know the difference between right and wrong.

JOE: (Pg 41) The only thing any asshole does, is that he succeeds in becoming infamous. And . . And he will become a mark in a history book, if we let him. How do you bury people like that so people forget them? Because that's what you need to do. You need to forget them.

CARLA: (Pg 42) There were these people demonstrating outside the National Shooting building. It's a resource for people who hunt and it's a very positive organization, and it's been here for decades. So people were outside it saying . . .

RABBI: (Pg 43) *(Leading this protest)* "GET OUT OF NEWTON! GET OUT! GET OUT!" We live in a society of 32,000 deaths by guns alone every year! IF these people died in the battlefields of Afghanistan, we wouldn't accept it. Yet when it happens right here in the cities of America, we somehow are mysteriously silent.

CARLA: I was just begging, begging for them to stop, stop making – stop perpetuating this hate. There's so much division now, and it's very strange, 'cause it's like *(snaps fingers)* overnight. *(Beat)*

DARREN: (Pg 45) We don't know all the things that are broken. We're still discovering them.

JULIE: (Pg 44) They seem to be okay for a while, then my son started to show signs of Post Traumatic Stress Disorder, PTSD. You just have that fear of not being safe. So kids, children, end up just being scared. They weren't scared of monsters before? Now they're scared of monsters.

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JOE: **(Pg 53)** This all leaves you with a lot of questions, and I don't think that's a bad thing. The more people are questioning, the more they're talking about it. "Where do we go from here? What can we learn from this? That's so cliché, but it's true. What can we learn from this?

YOLIE: It's all about how you ripple out, and what these vibrations can be. We are love. We are Newtown. That message says it all.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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Background Reference:
https://www.history.com/this-day-in-history/gunman-kills-students-and-adults-at-newtown-connecticut-elementary-school

Another selection based on the Sandy Hook Shooting is Choosing Hope by Kaitlin Roig-DeBellis and Robin Gaby Fisher

CUTTING STORED IN THE VAULT: Kaitlin Roig-Debellis is the first-grade teacher at Sandy Hook Elementary School who saved her entire class of fifteen six- and-seven-year-olds from the tragic events that took place on December 14, 2012, by piling them into a single-occupancy bathroom within her classroom, mere feet from the brutal and indiscriminate massacre taking place outside the door. Since then, despite the unimaginably painful experiences she endured, she has chosen to share her experience with others, in the hope that they too can find light in dark moments.

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